



Society for Academic Freedom and Scholarship

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30 June 2021

Dr Preston Smith
Dean, College of Medicine
University of Saskatchewan
107 Wiggins Rd
Saskatoon, SK S7N 5E5

Dear Dean Smith,

I am writing as president of the Society for Academic Freedom and Scholarship (SAFS), an organization of university faculty members and others dedicated to the defense of academic freedom and the merit principle in higher education. (For further information, see our website at www.safs.ca.)

According to a [news release](#) from the Justice Centre for Constitutional Freedoms, Dr Francis Christian has been suspended from all his responsibilities as a professor at the University of Saskatchewan and will be fired from the university at the beginning of September.

Suspending and firing a professor is, as you know, an extreme form of discipline. It is difficult to see what in this case would warrant it. Indeed, nothing that has been reported should draw any discipline at all, not even a letter of reprimand. Dr Christian is not alleged to be an incompetent or fraudulent researcher, nor an incompetent or abusive teacher. So far as the

information that has been made public goes, he has been suspended for having and expressing views with which administrators disagree. Dr Christian has questioned certain Covid-19 policies. Now even if administrators at the University of Saskatchewan find his expressed views false, academic freedom protects his rights to have them and to express them publicly.

In light of these considerations, SAFS would like to ask how Dr Christian's suspension is not a violation of his academic freedom and how his suspension will not tend to create a chilly climate for expression on campus?

It is extremely important in a time of pandemic that professors be free to question received wisdom and official policy. Their questions and criticisms could well lead to improvements in care and safety. Moreover, since Dr Christian's comments have implications for government policy, it is important that his voice not be silenced or that other critics be made fearful to speak out. If citizens are to be able to hold the government accountable for its decisions and

policies, they need to be able to consider informed critical views. The University of Saskatchewan's actions are contrary to the responsibility of universities to let experts engage in critical discussion.

We respectfully request that you respond to our letter. With your permission, we will post your response along with this letter on our website.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Mark Mercer', with a long horizontal flourish extending to the right.

Mark Mercer, PhD
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